

As part of the third day of the Privacy Symposium 2023 in Venice, on Wednesday, April 19, a panel titled "The Future of Data Protection Officers" was held, featuring the Director of the Agency, Zdravko Vukić. The panel, moderated by Pierre-Yves Lastic (European Federation of Data Protection Officers), included participants Judith Leschanz (Austrian Association of Data Protection Officers), Ali Zanjani (Austrian Supervisory Authority), and Cosimo Monda (European Centre for Privacy and Cybersecurity in Maastricht). The discussion focused on the role of data protection officers in the future, their readiness to face new challenges – a comprehensive set of new rules for all digital services such as the Digital Markets Act (DMA), the Digital Services Act, and the Artificial Intelligence Act.

During the panel, Director Vukić emphasized that this will be a challenge for data protection officers in Croatia, as they are often not sufficiently familiar with even the basics of personal data protection. He also pointed out that organizations in Croatia generally struggle with appointing an appropriate data protection officer and that the overall awareness of the importance of the officer's role is not sufficiently developed.

"Data protection officers do not have enough independence in their work, and very often their advice is not respected. They frequently struggle with avoiding conflicts of interest between their duties as data protection officers and other responsibilities within the organization. The Personal Data Protection Agency has always been a great support to data protection officers, and we continuously organize various training sessions specifically for them. However, despite all our efforts, the understanding of the importance of the role of data protection officers among data controllers, as well as their knowledge, remains at a low level to this day. There is no doubt that the role of data protection officers will become even more important and complex in the near future, and officers must be ready to face new challenges," said Director Vukić, emphasizing that the Agency will continue to raise awareness of the vital importance of the role of data protection officers.

The Privacy Symposium, held from April 17 to 21 in Venice, aims to support international dialogue, cooperation, and knowledge exchange on data protection by bringing together data protection experts, competent authorities, international organizations, and the research community to discuss the latest achievements and perspectives related to data protection and privacy. This year's focus of the Privacy Symposium was on international cooperation and the alignment of data protection regulations; new technology and compliance with data protection; and compliance with health and data protection requirements. The Symposium was hosted by Ca' Foscari University and organized in collaboration with several partners, including the Data Protection Unit of the Council of Europe, the European Centre for Certification and Privacy (ECCP), the European Law Students' Association (ELSA), the European Cybersecurity Organization (ECISO), the European Federation of Data Protection Officers (EFDPO), the European Centre for Privacy and Cybersecurity (ECPC), the Italian Institute for Privacy (IIP), the Italian Association for Cybersecurity (CLUSIT), the IoT Forum, Mandat International, IoT Lab, and European research projects such as Gatekeeper.